

This study goes *far* beyond just wedding vows but I'm pointing them out specifically because they are a simple example of how Egypt (as a picture of the world) has crept into the church of the living God while His stewards sleep ([Romans 13:11](#)). Copying the rudiments (fundamentals or traditions) of the world without first comparing them to God's word is often a recipe for sin ([Col 2:8](#), [Acts 17:11](#), [1Thess 5:21](#)). It's also part of the error of Balaam ([Jude 1:11](#)), that is to say, mixing godliness with worldliness.

Lord have mercy on us.

Numbers 30:1-3

¹ And Moses spake unto the heads of the tribes concerning the children of Israel, saying, This is the thing which the LORD hath commanded. ² If a man vow a vow unto the LORD, or swear an oath to bind his soul with a bond; he shall not break his word, he shall do according to all that proceedeth out of his mouth. ³ If a woman also vow a vow unto the LORD, and bind herself by a bond, being in her father's house in her youth;

- A vow is the same as swearing which is the same as an oath.
 - Which is the same as breaking one's word.
- Notice that the first part of verse 2 is between man and God and the second part of verse 2 is between anyone and anyone (split at the word "or").

Side note: what is a soul? Its the flesh and the spirit *together*: [Genesis 2:7](#). For example, when *most* people say "body" they are only referring to the flesh. Hence, the phrase "the body and the spirit" is necessary because the body without the spirit (breath of life) is dead ([James 2:26](#)).

Deuteronomy 23:21-23

²¹ When thou shalt vow a vow unto the LORD thy God, thou shalt not slack to pay it: for the LORD thy God will surely require it of thee; and it would be sin in thee. ²² But if thou shalt forbear to vow, it shall be no sin in thee. ²³ That which is gone out of thy lips thou shalt keep and perform; even a freewill offering, according as thou hast vowed unto the LORD thy God, which thou hast promised with thy mouth.

- Making a vow unto the LORD and not fulfilling it is sin.
- The vow must be performed exactly how it was spoken (including how and when).
- A verbal vow is the same as a verbal promise.

Ecclesiastes 5:4-6

⁴ When thou vowest a vow unto God, defer not to pay it; for he hath no pleasure in fools: pay that which thou hast vowed. ⁵ Better is it that thou shouldest not vow, than that thou shouldest vow and not pay. ⁶ Suffer not thy mouth to cause thy flesh to sin; neither say thou before the angel, that it was an error: wherefore should God be angry at thy voice, and destroy the work of thine hands?

- A man that vows something to God and does not perform it is a fool.
- It's better to not vow at all than to vow and not perform it.

Leviticus 5:4

⁴ Or if a soul swear, pronouncing with his lips to do evil, or to do good, whatsoever it be that a man shall pronounce with an oath, and it be hid from him; when he knoweth of it, then he shall be guilty in one of these.

- To swear is the same as an oath.

Deuteronomy 29:12

That thou shouldest enter into covenant with the LORD thy God, and into his oath, which the LORD thy God maketh with thee this day:

- To make a covenant is to make an oath.

Matthew 5:33-37

- ³³ Again, ye have heard that it hath been said by them of old time, Thou shalt not forswear thyself, but shalt perform unto the Lord thine oaths:
- ³⁴ But I say unto you, Swear not at all; neither by heaven; for it is God's throne:
- ³⁵ Nor by the earth; for it is his footstool: neither by Jerusalem; for it is the city of the great King.
- ³⁶ Neither shalt thou swear by thy head, because thou canst not make one hair white or black.
- ³⁷ But let your communication be, Yea, yea; Nay, nay: for whatsoever is more than these cometh of evil.

James 5:12

But above all things, my brethren, swear not, neither by heaven, neither by the earth, neither by any other oath: but let your yea be yea; and your nay, nay; lest ye fall into condemnation.

- To “forswear thyself” is to commit perjury against yourself.
 - Perjury is to swear falsely.
 - Swearing falsely is the same as bearing false witness (Exo 20:16, Pro 6:16-19).
 - Which is the same as lying (Rev 21:16, 21:27).
- Jesus goes right to the heart of the matter and we are commanded to “Swear not at all”.
- An oath is the same as swearing (Lev 5:4).
- Anything more than yes or no comes from evil (and therefore is evil Gal 5:9).

Let's put together the equivalences that we've gathered from God's word:

- The “umbrella” is “a binding agreement between two parties with words” (Num 30:2c)
 - to swear
 - to make an oath
 - to make a vow
 - to promise
 - to make a covenant (or a league)

Note that these are not all *exactly* equal but because of their interconnectedness they all deal with the same basic matters: guaranteeing something to someone in the future, guaranteeing something will or will not happen in the future, or guaranteeing that you will or won't do something in the future. Proverbs 27:1, Matthew 5:36b, and James 4:13-16 all explain to us why doing those things are not only foolish but also they are sin.

By looking at all of God's word we can learn that the swearing Jesus was talking about encompasses far more than what we might initially suspect if we do not take a careful look at all of scripture like we are commanded to (2Ti 2:15).

Jesus makes the points in the old testament crystal clear by simply **commanding** us to not swear at all – not to God nor to each other nor to anything or by anything. Moreover, He also explains to us why for us it doesn't make any sense to promise anything in the future.

Proverbs 27:1

Boast not thyself of to morrow; for thou knowest not what a day may bring forth.

James 4:13-16

¹³ Go to now, ye that say, To day or to morrow we will go into such a city, and continue there a year, and buy and sell, and get gain: ¹⁴ Whereas ye know not what shall be on the morrow. For what is your life? It is even a vapour, that appeareth for a little time, and then vanisheth away. ¹⁵ For that ye ought to say, If the Lord will, we shall live, and do this, or that. ¹⁶ But now ye rejoice in your boastings: all such rejoicing is evil.

We can't guarantee that anything will or won't happen. If we can't guarantee something will or won't happen and we can't make that change happen ([Mat 5:36b](#)) how then can we also guarantee that if we make a promise/oath/swear that we aren't lying? We simply can't. So, it's a fools errand and self-deception at best to promise anything. Hence, keep it simple: yes or no (anything more than that is evil). Moreover, [James 4:13-16](#) shows us just how easily we can compound sin on top of sin by then *boasting* about something we can't even ensure happens.

Summary:

- Do not make any verbal, binding agreement to anyone by anything. Simply say "yes" or "no". This includes but is not limited to:
 - Do not swear to anyone by anything
 - Do not make oaths to anyone by anything
 - Do not make vows to anyone by anything
 - Do not make/give promises to anyone by anything
 - Do not make a covenant/league with anyone by anything

Bonus: the world is almost constantly changing definitions and adding vocabulary to masquerade sin as something else. Some examples related to this context (dependent on how they are used): guarantee, undertaking, contract, commitment, word of honor.